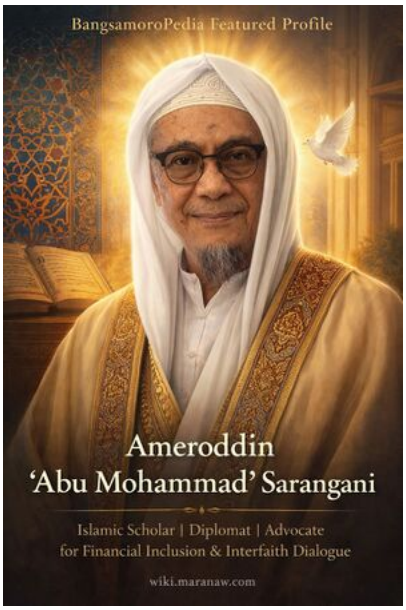
Ameroddin "Abu Mohammad" Sarangani

Ameroddin "Abu Mohammad" Sarangani is a distinguished Filipino Islamic scholar (Alim), religious leader, and diplomat who served as the Philippine Special Envoy for Islamic Affairs. A prominent Maranao figure, he's recognized for bridging the Philippine government and the global Muslim community while advocating for Islamic banking and interfaith dialogue. His legacy centers on the integration of Islamic principles into national governance and the empowerment of Bangsamoro communities through education and economic opportunity.

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Ameroddin "Abu Mohammad" Sarangani



Full Name	Ameroddin Sarangani
Title	Abu Mohammad (Father of Mohammad)
Ethnicity	Maranao
Religion	Islam
Nationality	Filipino
Known For	Special Envoy for Islamic Affairs; Islamic finance advocacy; interfaith dialogue; educational exchange
Education	Kuwait University (Islamic Jurisprudence, Arabic)
Notable Role	Philippine Special Envoy for Islamic Affairs

Early Life and Background

Ameroddin Sarangani was born and raised in Lanao del Sur, on the island of Mindanao. He belongs to the Maranao ethnic group, known as the "people of the lake" for their historical connection to Lake Lanao and their rich cultural traditions deeply rooted in Islamic faith. Growing up within the traditional social structures of the Lanao sultanates, his early life was shaped by the ethical teachings of Islam and family traditions of regional leadership. This dual heritage of Maranao identity and Islamic scholarship became the foundation of his life's work.

Education

Sarangani's academic journey blended traditional Islamic learning with international university education. He pursued advanced studies in Sharia (Islamic law) and theology, earning the respected title of *Alim*, a designation reserved for Islamic scholars who have demonstrated mastery of Islamic jurisprudence and theology.

His international education took him to Kuwait University, where he gained fluency in Arabic and developed a nuanced understanding of Middle Eastern geopolitics and Islamic scholarship traditions. This educational foundation became the cornerstone of his later diplomatic work, allowing him to navigate complex international conversations about Islam and Muslim affairs with both scholarly authority and cultural sensitivity. The combination of traditional Islamic training and modern university education positioned him uniquely to serve as a bridge between the Philippine government and the international Muslim community.

Career and Diplomatic Service

Special Envoy for Islamic Affairs

Sarangani's most significant professional contribution came through his service as the **Philippine Special Envoy for Islamic Affairs**, a formal presidential designation empowering him to represent the President in matters of religious and regional importance. This role recognized his standing as both a scholar and a diplomat capable of engaging with complex questions of governance, faith, and international relations.

Hajj Coordination and Pilgrimage Leadership

One of his most notable achievements was his oversight of the Hajj pilgrimage process, particularly during 2011. His work focused on streamlining the logistics for thousands of Filipino pilgrims traveling to Mecca. His responsibilities included negotiating fair pilgrimage quotas with the Saudi Ministry of Hajj, improving transportation and housing standards to meet international safety protocols, and serving as a diplomatic liaison to resolve administrative challenges with Saudi authorities. These efforts ensured smoother visa processing and documentation for Filipino Muslims undertaking this central Islamic obligation.

> "Providing pilgrims with safe passage and dignified treatment is not merely an administrative task, but a sacred trust. The Hajj is the spiritual journey of a lifetime, and our role is to ensure that every Filipino Muslim can undertake it with peace of mind."

Liaison to the Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC)

As a primary point of contact between the Philippine government and the Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC), which comprises 57 member states, Sarangani was tasked with explaining Philippine domestic policies to the international Muslim community. He worked to ensure international understanding and support for regional stability in Mindanao, effectively serving as a cultural and political translator between Manila and the Muslim world.

Educational Exchange Programs

Leveraging his ties to prestigious Middle Eastern academic institutions, Sarangani facilitated scholarship programs for Filipino students to study at renowned centers such as Al-Azhar University in Egypt. These initiatives expanded opportunities for young Bangsamoro Muslims to access world-class Islamic education and return to their communities as leaders, educators, and advocates for social development.

Contributions to Islamic Banking

Sarangani has been a vocal advocate for integrating Islamic finance into the Philippine national economy. Recognizing that many Muslim Filipinos avoid conventional banking for religious reasons, he argued that providing interest-free banking options is essential for financial inclusion in Muslim-majority communities.

His work supported the evolution of the Al-Amanah Islamic Investment Bank of the Philippines (AAIIBP), the country's first and only state-owned Islamic bank. He provided scholarly guidance emphasizing core Islamic finance principles, particularly the prohibition of *riba* (usury) and the promotion of risk-sharing models like *musharakah* (profit-sharing partnerships) and *murabahah* (cost-plus-profit arrangements). These models align banking practice with Islamic values while serving the economic development of Mindanao and the BARMM.

By promoting Islamic banking as a tool for socioeconomic development, Sarangani connected spiritual principles to tangible economic empowerment, demonstrating that faith and finance could work in harmony for community benefit.

Institutional Leadership and Ulama Councils

Sarangani has held leadership positions in various councils of Islamic scholars (*Ulama*), advocating for their active participation in civic life and ethical governance. Rather than viewing religious authority and public service as separate domains, he championed the idea that Islamic scholars have a responsibility to contribute to the moral and political life of the nation.

Interfaith Dialogue

He has been a consistent proponent of the Bishops-Ulama Conference, an organization dedicated to fostering mutual respect and peaceful coexistence between Muslim and Christian communities in Mindanao. This work reflects his belief that the diversity of Mindanao is a strength to be celebrated and protected, not an obstacle to be overcome. Through dialogue and collaborative action, he worked to build bridges between faith communities and reduce misunderstandings that could fuel conflict.

Personal Values and Philosophy

Sarangani's work is underpinned by three core values: **peace, moral integrity, and social justice**. He frequently emphasizes that Islamic principles are compatible with modern democratic service and views education as the primary tool for community empowerment.

His philosophical approach centers on the concept of the *Wasatiyyah* (the "Middle Way"), promoting moderation and explicitly rejecting extremist interpretations of faith. This principle grounds his diplomatic work, his advocacy for interfaith dialogue, and his vision of Islamic banking as a inclusive, ethical alternative to conventional finance.

> "The true measure of a scholar is not how loudly he speaks, but how effectively he serves his community. Islam calls us to be bridges, not walls, between peoples."

Cultural Significance and Legacy

In the cultural landscape of Mindanao and the Bangsamoro region, Sarangani is regarded as a vital link between traditional Maranao heritage and modern statecraft. As a scholar-diplomat, he embodies the possibility of integrating Islamic identity and Maranao culture into broader national and international frameworks without loss of authenticity or pride.

His work has demonstrated that religious authority and secular governance need not be in tension. Instead, when guided by principles of integrity, scholarship, and dialogue, Islamic leadership can contribute meaningfully to nation-building and regional stability. Sarangani has shown that the Bangsamoro people, and the Maranao in particular, have much to offer the Philippines and the world, not as supplicants seeking recognition but as dignified partners with wisdom and values to share.

Political Engagement and Community Leadership

Sarangani has remained engaged in provincial affairs beyond his diplomatic roles. He served as a former chairman of the Lanao del Sur Electric Cooperative, demonstrating his commitment to practical community development. His 2022 gubernatorial candidacy in Lanao del Sur, filed under the Ummah Party, reflected his willingness to extend his advocacy for Islamic principles and good governance into the electoral arena, mobilizing imams and religious leaders around a vision of ethical leadership.

Recognition and Influence

As a respected Islamic scholar with formal training in Islamic jurisprudence, international experience, and diplomatic credentials, Sarangani has earned recognition among Muslim leaders, government officials, and international observers. His contributions to Islamic banking policy, educational exchange, and interfaith relations have shaped institutional development and public discourse around Islam in the Philippines.

References

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Further Reading

- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)
- Islamic banking in the Philippines
- Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC)

- Bishops-Ulama Conference
- Maranao culture and history
- Islamic jurisprudence and Sharia

See Also

- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Al-Amanah Islamic Investment Bank of the Philippines
- Islamic Law in the Philippines
- Lanao del Sur
- Bangsamoro people

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